AI-FIRST STRATEGY

Building the AI-First Marketing Function

How a deep generalist with production AI systems operates as a full marketing department. Not a pitch. A portfolio of working tools and the philosophy behind them.

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PRODUCTION TOOLS	APIS INTEGRATED	FUNCTIONS COVERED	PERSON

THE LANDSCAPE

The Rules Changed. Most People Haven't Noticed.

The market is converging on a single insight: one marketer with AI systems can outproduce an entire team.

What the Industry is Saying

- "One growth marketer with AI systems outproduces a 5-person agency team. This isn't a thought experiment. It's my Tuesday." (GrowthMarketer, March 2026)
- "2026 is the Year of the Full-Stack AI Marketer." (Kieran Flanagan, former SVP Marketing at HubSpot)
- "The competitive advantage is not access to AI. Everyone has access. The advantage is clarity of strategy." (Hot in Social Media, 2026)
- "Marketers in 2026 aren't becoming AI engineers. They're becoming AI orchestrators." (CMSWire, January 2026)

What This Actually Means

AI doesn't replace strategy, taste, or cross-functional judgment. It replaces the execution bottleneck that used to require a team of specialists.

A marketer who can think across the full stack (positioning, growth, product, design, analytics, enablement, competitive intel) and build AI systems to execute across it is no longer a generalist.

They're a marketing function.

> *"AI doesn't replace the best. It replaces the baseline and lifts it dramatically. The tools matter less than how they're orchestrated."*
>
> INDUSTRY CONSENSUS, 2026

THE THESIS

The Fundamentals Are What Matter. The Tools Are Interchangeable.

This approach is agnostic of any specific tool, API, or platform. The value is in the strategic architecture, not the vendor.

THE BUILDER-STRATEGIST

Most marketers use AI to write faster. I build production systems that make entire functions operational. The tools keep working after I move on to the next problem. That's the distinction between adoption and infrastructure.

WHY GENERALISTS WIN NOW

The old world punished generalists. Deep knowledge across positioning, growth, product, design, and analytics meant you didn't fit neatly into a single job description. The new world rewards exactly that. AI removes the execution bottleneck. Cross-functional judgment becomes the multiplier.

TOOL-AGNOSTIC BY DESIGN

HubSpot? We pipe into HubSpot. Salesforce? We do that. Leads from Apollo, ZoomInfo, Clay, or any of the billion scraper tools out there? We connect those. Slack or Teams? Doesn't matter. The philosophy is: find the connectors that work and put rocket fuel in whatever system already exists.

THE PRINCIPLE

- Good prompts help. Good product design is what makes them repeatable.
- AI tools are only useful when the surrounding structure is strong.
- The research has to be right before the system can be right.
- Every company has a different stack. The skill is integration, not allegiance.

WHAT I'VE BUILT WITH

- Claude API, OpenAI API, Deepgram for intelligence layers
- Claude Code for building and shipping daily
- Jina Reader, Firecrawl for web intelligence
- X API, Reddit API for social signals
- Azure, Vercel, Node.js, Next.js
- Tomorrow it could be anything else. The pattern transfers.

WHAT I'VE SHIPPED

- Buyer intelligence content engine (production)
- Competitive intelligence aggregator (production)
- Voice-to-text research application
- Portfolio site, landing pages, sales tools
- This entire visual portfolio

PRODUCTION TOOL

Buyer Intelligence Content Engine

Takes structured buyer journey inputs and returns ranked, confidence-scored content recommendations. Makes research operational.

The Problem It Solves

Deep buyer research loses its value the moment it sits in a slide deck. A demand gen lead planning a campaign starts from scratch instead of mining existing intelligence. A salesperson preparing for a meeting relies on instinct instead of the research infrastructure available to them.

This tool closes that gap. The research stays alive and keeps working.

How It Works

- Input the initiative, buying job, buying engines, priority, audience, and trigger context
- System returns top 3 ranked content recommendations with confidence scores
- Each recommendation includes channel, format, and audience alignment
- Full structured outline for the top-ranked asset
- Proof requirements across Financial, Operational, Technical, and Risk dimensions
- Objection handling mapped by buying engine

Inputs
Initiative, Buying Job, Buying Engines (4), Strategic Priority, Audience Type, Trigger Context

↓

AI Processing Layer
OpenAI API, structured prompt architecture, JSON-shaped outputs, buyer intelligence reference data

↓

Outputs
Ranked recommendations, confidence scores, channel alignment, structured outlines, proof requirements, objection handling

Deployed: Azure Static Apps, Microsoft ecosystem integration. **Built with:** HTML/CSS/JS, OpenAI API.

PRODUCTION TOOL

Competitive Intelligence Aggregator

Multi-source competitive monitoring that classifies signals automatically. Replaces manual competitive research with a persistent system.

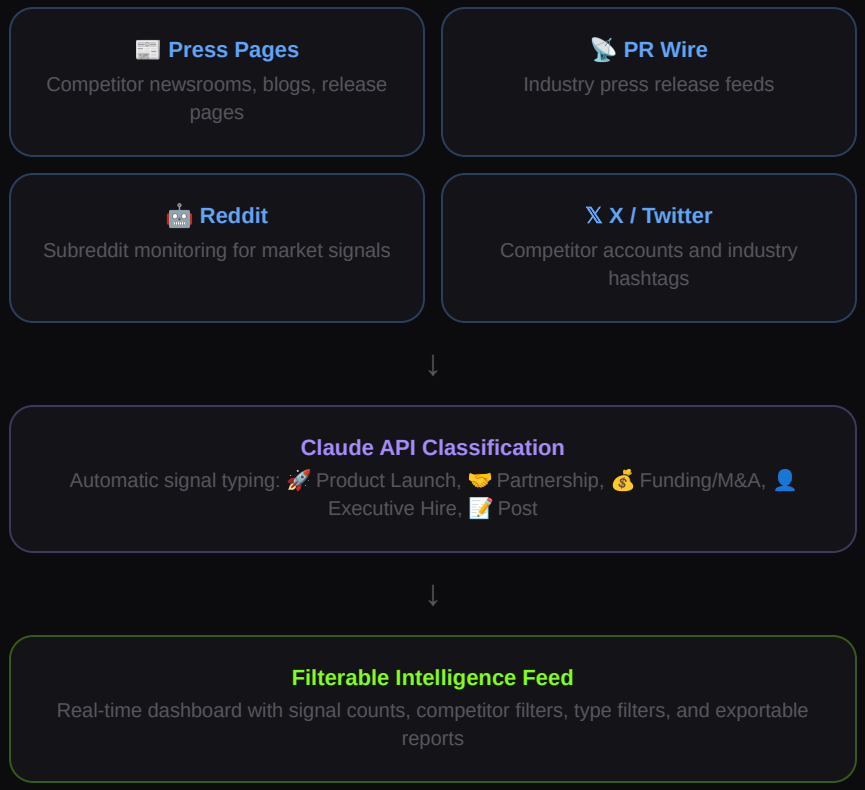
The Problem It Solves

Competitive intelligence at most companies is a quarterly slide deck that's outdated by the time it's presented. Conferences, product launches, partnerships, funding rounds, and executive hires happen continuously. No one is watching all the sources, all the time.

This tool does. It monitors press pages, PR wires, Reddit, and X for competitor activity. Signals are classified automatically by type: product launch, partnership, funding/M&A, executive hire, or general post.

The Architecture

- **Jina Reader + Firecrawl:** Web scraping and content extraction from competitor press pages
- **X API + Reddit API:** Social signal monitoring for real-time market chatter
- **Claude API:** Signal classification and intelligence summarization
- **Deployed on Vercel** with persistent monitoring



THE BIGGER VISION

Compound Intelligence: The Self-Maintaining Marketing Engine

The next frontier isn't individual tools. It's a persistent knowledge system that gets smarter with every interaction.

The Karpathy Pattern, Applied to Marketing

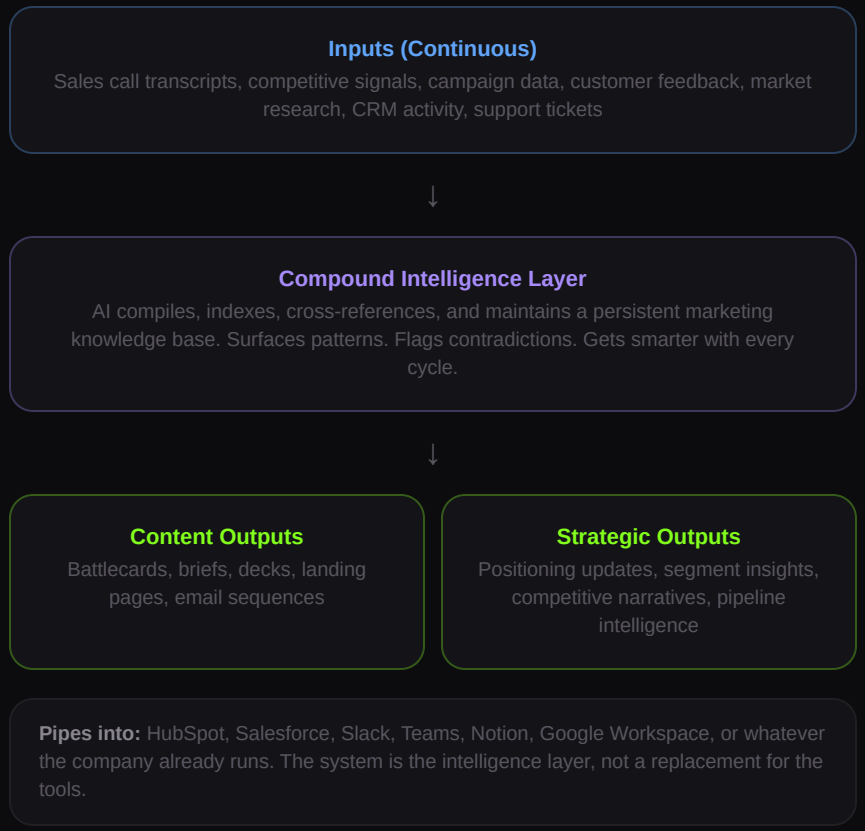
Andrej Karpathy recently described an AI system that builds and maintains a self-updating knowledge base from raw research. No vector databases, no complex RAG pipelines. Just an LLM that compiles, indexes, cross-references, and heals its own knowledge over time. 100 articles, 400,000 words, zero manual maintenance.

That pattern is designed for personal knowledge management. Now imagine it pointed at a marketing function.

The Marketing Application

Every sales call transcript, every competitive signal, every campaign performance report, every customer conversation flows into a persistent intelligence layer. The system compiles it, cross-references it, surfaces patterns, and feeds outputs directly into whatever tools the company already uses.

The buyer research from Q1 doesn't sit in a slide deck. It compounds. The competitive signals from last month inform this month's positioning. The objection patterns from 50 sales calls become next quarter's content strategy. Nothing starts from scratch.



DAILY OPERATIONS

The System Behind the Systems

AI isn't a tool I use sometimes. It's the operating layer for everything I build and ship.

CLAUDE CODE: THE BUILD LAYER

This is the biggest unlock. When a marketer can build landing pages, implement tracking, create custom reporting dashboards, and ship experiments without a developer, the entire speed equation changes. I'm not waiting on engineering tickets. I'm building and shipping in the same afternoon I have the idea.

CLAUDE: THE STRATEGY LAYER

Research synthesis, competitive analysis, positioning work, content architecture, interview prep, messaging frameworks. The AI handles volume and first-draft structure. I provide the judgment, the taste, and the domain expertise that makes outputs specific instead of generic.

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

- Built a 76-slide buyer persona library with AI-assisted research synthesis
- This entire visual portfolio was built in a single working session
- Landing pages go from concept to live in hours, not weeks
- Competitive analysis that would take a team a week takes an afternoon
- Sales training materials that integrate live research, not stale decks

THE MULTIPLIER EFFECT

The AI handles the volume. I provide the judgment. The output is not AI-generated content. It's AI-accelerated strategy, built by someone who understands what good looks like across every marketing function. That distinction is everything.

CAPABILITY MAP

What One Person Covers

Each function backed by real experience and amplified by AI systems. Not theoretical. Built and shipped.

🎯

Positioning & Messaging

April Dunford methodology, messaging hierarchies, competitive narratives, value proposition development

AI: RESEARCH SYNTHESIS, COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

📊

Growth & PLG

Newsletter scaling (0 to 200K), conversion optimization, activation moments, full-funnel experimentation

AI: A/B TEST ANALYSIS, FUNNEL MODELING

🧠

Buyer Intelligence

Enterprise persona libraries, segmentation frameworks, buyer journey architecture, stakeholder mapping

AI: CONTENT ENGINE, RESEARCH AUTOMATION

⚔️

Competitive Intel

Market monitoring, signal classification, competitive messaging matrices, conference preparation

AI: CI AGGREGATOR, AUTOMATED MONITORING

🎨

Product & UX Design

Full UX/UI in Figma, PRDs, gamification systems, phased rollout strategy, user research

AI: PROTOTYPING, DESIGN SYSTEM GENERATION

📈

Analytics & CRO

Amplitude implementation from scratch, product analytics, pricing experiments, attribution

AI: DATA ANALYSIS, DASHBOARD BUILDING

🏋️

Sales Enablement

Company-wide training, persona-driven battlecards, deal preparation materials, content recommendations

AI: CONTENT ENGINE, DECK GENERATION

🔧

Marketing Engineering

Landing pages, web apps, API integrations, ESP automation, tracking implementation

AI: CLAUDE CODE, FULL-STACK BUILDING

MARKET CONTEXT

The Industry is Catching Up

What was fringe a year ago is now the consensus position among the people who are actually shipping.

THE ONE-PERSON TEAM

"I run growth for multiple companies simultaneously. Not with a team of 40. Not with an army of freelancers. With AI-native systems that let one experienced growth marketer outproduce a traditional agency team of five."

GROWTHMARKETER, MARCH 2026

THE FULL-STACK MARKETER

"Stop working alone. Build three AI assistants: a Data Strategist, a Chief of Staff, and a Customer Vocabulary Engine. The marketers who obsess over customer vs. clicks will win."

KIERAN FLANAGAN, DECEMBER 2025

THE AI ORCHESTRATOR

"Marketers in 2026 aren't becoming AI engineers. They're becoming AI orchestrators. Competitive advantage comes from orchestration, not engineering. Teams that architect intelligent systems will outpace competitors treating AI as just another tool."

CMSWIRE, JANUARY 2026

THE SIGNAL VS. NOISE PROBLEM

"The mistake most teams make is using AI to produce more content faster. The teams winning use AI to understand what content actually influences decisions and then produce less, but better. Volume without strategic input just creates noise."

HOT IN SOCIAL MEDIA, 2026

SUMMARY

The Work Speaks

Every tool is live. Every system is production. The portfolio you're reading was built this way.

BUYER INTELLIGENCE CONTENT ENGINE

Production web app. OpenAI API on Azure. Turns structured buyer journey inputs into ranked content recommendations with confidence scoring, proof requirements, and objection handling. Used by demand gen and sales teams.

COMPETITIVE INTELLIGENCE AGGREGATOR

Multi-API platform. Claude + Jina Reader + Firecrawl + X + Reddit. Monitors competitor activity across press, social, and PR. Classifies signals automatically. Deployed on Vercel.

THIS PORTFOLIO

Five interactive case studies. Built in a single working session using Claude. Designed, written, and shipped as production HTML. Embedded on a Next.js site. The medium is the message.

WHAT I BRING

- Deep cross-functional marketing experience (positioning, growth, product, design, analytics, enablement)
- Production AI systems that operationalize research and automate intelligence
- The ability to build and ship without waiting on engineering
- A 200K-subscriber newsletter, a Fortune 10 buyer intelligence program, and a full gamification system as proof
- The judgment to know when AI accelerates the work and when it needs to stay out of the way

THE POINT

The question isn't whether one person can cover the full marketing function anymore. The tools exist. The systems exist. The question is whether that person has the strategic depth and cross-functional judgment to make it work.

This portfolio is the answer.